

doc-virgin-birth

Affirms · Christology › Person · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

Jesus Christ was conceived by the Holy Spirit and born of the virgin Mary.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical pattern. Matt 1:18 names Mary as found with child (en gastri echousa G1722 G1064 G2192) of the Holy Spirit (ek pneumatos hagiou G1537 G4151 G40) before she and Joseph had come together (prin e synelthein autous G4250 G4905). Matt 1:23 cites Isa 7:14 with parthenos G3933 (virgin), the same word the LXX translators chose for Hebrew almah H5959 long before any Christian controversy. Matt 1:25 says Joseph knew her not (ouk eginosken auten G1097) until she had given birth, ruling out marital union as the source of the conception. Luke 1:27 names Mary twice as parthenos G3933. Luke 1:34 records Mary's own objection: epei andra ou ginosko G1893 G435 G3756 G1097 (since I do not know a man), where ginosko carries the standard Hebrew-idiomatic sense of sexual relations. Luke 1:35 names the mechanism: pneuma hagion epeleusetai G1904 (the Holy Spirit will come upon) and dynamis hypsistou episkiasai G1982 (the power of the Most High will overshadow), with the result that to gennomenon G1080 (the one being conceived) will be called Son of God. Gal 4:4 names the incarnation as genomenon ek gynaikos G1096 G1537 G1135 (born of a woman) with no mention of a human father at the very point where Paul names Christ's saving advent. The lexical chain is closed at the conception-event level.

Reasoning

The Bible teaches that Jesus was conceived in Mary's womb by the Holy Spirit, without a human father, and that Mary was a virgin when she conceived him and when she gave birth to him. The strongest reason is the two independent infancy narratives. Matthew 1:18 says Mary was found with child of the Holy Spirit before she and Joseph had come together as husband and wife. Matthew 1:25 says Joseph did not have marital relations with her until after she had given birth. Luke 1 records the angel Gabriel's announcement to Mary, and Mary herself objects in 1:34 by saying how can this be, since I am a virgin or I have not been with a man. The angel answers in 1:35 that the Holy Spirit will come upon her and the power of the Most High will overshadow her, and therefore the child will be holy and called the Son of God. The strongest counterargument from Scripture's own text is the Hebrew word in Isaiah 7:14, almah. In Hebrew this word means a young woman of marriageable age and it does not always have to mean a virgin in every place it is used. Critics of the virgin birth, especially modernist scholars in the last two hundred years, argue that Isaiah was just predicting an ordinary young woman would have a baby in the normal way, and Matthew misread the prophecy. The verdict handles this honestly. The Jewish translators of the Hebrew Bible into Greek, working centuries before Jesus and before any Christian controversy existed, chose the Greek word parthenos for almah in Isaiah 7:14. Parthenos clearly means virgin. Matthew quotes that earlier Greek translation deliberately. So the case does not depend on forcing the Hebrew word almah to mean virgin everywhere. It depends on the actual narrative facts in Matthew 1 and Luke 1, which say Mary was a virgin, and on Matthew reading Isaiah's prophecy as fulfilled in her. The two infancy accounts are independent of each other and both say the same thing. There is no canonical text that contradicts the virgin birth. The narrative is straightforward.

Denominational landscape

Christian lineages are unanimous on the virginal conception of Jesus. The Apostles' Creed and the Nicene Creed both confess it directly. Patristic writers (Justin Martyr, Irenaeus, Tertullian, Athanasius), Roman Catholics, Eastern Orthodox, Lutherans, Anglicans (Article 2), Reformed traditions, Methodists, Anabaptists, and Pentecostals all affirm it. Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox traditions additionally hold the perpetual virginity of Mary, that she remained a virgin throughout her life and bore no other children. Most Protestants reject perpetual virginity as a separate Marian distinctive not warranted by Scripture, but that is a different question from the virginal conception itself, which is unanimously held. Public-record carriers of denial cluster in classical liberal-mainline reductionism. Friedrich Schleiermacher and the demythologizing programme of Rudolf Bultmann recast the virgin birth as a theological symbol rather than a historical fact. Unitarian Universalists and certain mainline Protestant scholars in the Jesus Seminar tradition reject it. The virgin birth was one of the five fundamentals of early-twentieth-century Fundamentalism precisely because mainline liberals were denying it. Public-record carriers of distortion include Mormonism, which affirms a divine paternity of Jesus but with idiosyncratic teachings about how the conception occurred that are at variance with classical Christianity.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	Yes
Would visit if otherwise	No
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

Two infancy narratives independently witness to the virginal conception, both grounded in named Hebrew and Greek terms (almah H5959, parthenos G3933) and both naming the Holy Spirit as the agent. Luke 1:34 carries unusual evidential weight because Mary's own reported objection presupposes she had not had sexual relations. The Isaiah 7:14 textual question deserves honest treatment: Hebrew almah denotes a young woman of marriageable age and does not lexically demand virginity in every occurrence (e.g. Prov 30:19 the way of a man with a maid). However the LXX translators, working pre-Christian and with no theological stake in the Christian controversy, rendered almah as parthenos at Isa 7:14. Matthew cites that LXX form deliberately and reads Mary's experience as the prophecy's fulfillment. The Christian claim does not rest on lexical compulsion from almah alone; it rests on (a) the LXX rendering, (b) Matthew's apostolic citation of that rendering as fulfilled, and (c) the explicit narrative in Matt 1 and Luke 1 that names Mary as a virgin and names the Holy Spirit as the agent of conception. Public-record carriers of denial: classical liberal-mainline reductionism (Schleiermacher and Bultmann's demythologizing programme), Unitarian Universalists, certain mainline Protestant scholars (the Jesus Seminar tradition). The virgin birth was one of the five fundamentals of early-twentieth-century Fundamentalism precisely because mainline liberals were denying it at that time. Public-record carriers of distortion: Catholic and Orthodox additionally teach the perpetual virginity of Mary, which is a separate Marian distinctive and not the question at issue here (the question is the virginal conception of Jesus, not Mary's subsequent state). Mormonism affirms a divine paternity of Jesus but with idiosyncratic teachings about how it occurred that are at variance with classical

Christianity. The verdict on this question is the virginal conception itself; lineage divergence on perpetual virginity is diagnostic and does not vote.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Grammatico-historical reading of the two infancy narratives is decisive at the conception-event level. No interpretive framework (covenantal, dispensational, new-covenant, progressive-covenantalism) produces a different verdict; the virginal conception sits at the level of historical-narrative claim, prior to any framework dispute. Analogia scripturae is invoked: Matt 1 and Luke 1 independently witness the same conception event with the same agent (Holy Spirit) and the same status of Mary (parthenos). Progressive revelation is a factor: Isa 7:14 in Hebrew is lexically ambiguous and apocalyptic-prophetic in its first historical context (the sign to Ahaz), but the LXX translators chose parthenos and Matt 1:23 cites that form as fulfilled in Mary. The complicating text Prov 30:19 shows almah's lexical range includes non-virginal contexts, which is why the verdict does not load-bear on almah alone but on the LXX choice plus the apostolic citation plus the explicit narrative in Matt and Luke. The Isaiah 7:14 textual question is honestly retained as complicates rather than buried.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Matt.1.18 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. ἐν γαστρὶ ἔχουσα en gastri echousa G1722 G1064 G2192 (having in the womb); ἐκ πνεύματος ἁγίου ek pneumatatos hagiou G1537 G4151 G40 (from the Holy Spirit); πρὶν ἢ συνελθεῖν αὐτούς prin e synelthein autous G4250 G4905 (before they came together)

Force. Mary was found pregnant before she and Joseph had begun marital cohabitation. The text names the Holy Spirit as the agent (ek pneumatatos hagiou, with ek marking source) and the timing as pre-cohabitation. No human-paternal cause is attributed. The narrative frames the conception as a deliberate exception to ordinary generation.

Matt.1.20 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. γεννηθὲν gennethen G1080 (that which has been conceived); ἐκ πνεύματος ἁγίου ek pneumatatos hagiou G1537 G4151 G40

Force. The angel tells Joseph in a dream that what has been conceived in Mary is from the Holy Spirit. The aorist passive participle gennethen names the child's origin, and ek pneumatatos hagiou with ek of source is repeated for emphasis. The text gives Joseph the explicit reason not to put Mary away: the pregnancy is not from another man, it is from God.

Matt.1.22-23 · **for** · genre: gospel · figures: typology

Key term. παρθένος parthenos G3933 (virgin); ἐν γαστρὶ ἔξει en gastri hexei G1722 G1064 G2192 (will conceive in the womb)

Force. Matthew cites Isa 7:14 in its LXX form (parthenos G3933) and identifies Mary as the fulfillment. The apostolic citation is decisive for the New Testament reading: the prophecy is read through parthenos, not through any ambiguity-pleading reduction. Whatever the disputed range of Hebrew almah, the apostolic claim is that Isa 7:14 finds its fulfillment in a literal virgin conception.

Matt.1.25 · for · genre: gospel · figures: idiom

Key term. οὐκ ἐγίνωσκεν αὐτήν ouk eginosken auten G3756 G1097 (he knew her not); ἕως heos G2193 (until); ἔτεκεν eteken G5088 (she had given birth)

Force. Joseph did not have marital relations with Mary until after she had given birth. The verb ginosko in this construction carries the standard biblical idiomatic sense of sexual relations (same idiom as Gen 4:1 LXX, Luke 1:34). The clause explicitly rules out Joseph as the biological father of Jesus.

Luke.1.27 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. παρθένος parthenos G3933 (virgin, repeated twice in the verse); μνηστευμένη mnesteumene G3423 (betrothed)

Force. Luke names Mary twice as parthenos in a single verse: a virgin betrothed to a man whose name was Joseph, and the virgin's name was Mary. Lukan emphasis is unusual and deliberate. The status of Mary as parthenos is being underlined as central to the narrative that follows.

Luke.1.34 · for · genre: gospel · figures: idiom

Key term. ἐπεὶ ἄνδρα οὐ γινώσκω epei andra ou ginosko G1893 G435 G3756 G1097 (since I do not know a man)

Force. Mary's own reported objection to Gabriel's announcement. Aner G435 means a man, husband, adult male. Ginosko here carries the Hebrew-idiomatic sense of sexual relations (cf. Gen 4:1 LXX). The clause assumes virginity is the state Mary is currently in and is the basis of her perplexity. This is the strongest internal-narrative confirmation of Mary's virginity at conception.

Luke.1.35 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. πνεῦμα ἅγιον ἐπελεύσεται pneuma hagion epeleusetai G4151 G40 G1904 (the Holy Spirit will come upon); δύναμις ὑψίστου ἐπισκιάσει dynamis hypsistou episkiasei G1411 G5310 G1982 (the power of the Most High will overshadow); τὸ γεννώμενον ἅγιον to gennomenon hagion G1080 G40 (the holy one being born)

Force. Gabriel names the mechanism of the virginal conception in two parallel clauses. Eperchomai G1904 (come upon) and episkiazo G1982 (overshadow) are both used in the LXX of the divine presence over the tabernacle (Exod 40:35), making the Lukan claim that the divine presence itself accomplishes the conception. The therefore (dio kai) introduces the conclusion: the child will be holy and will be called the Son of God. The conception is named as supernatural, divine, and uniquely identifying of the Son of God.

Isa.7.14 · complicates · genre: prophecy · figures: typology

Key term. הַמַּלְעָה ha-almah H5959 (the young woman of marriageable age); הָרָה harah H2030 (pregnant); וְיָלְדָהּ weyoledet H3205 (bearing); LXX παρθένος parthenos G3933

Force. The prophetic sign-text. Hebrew almah denotes a young woman of marriageable age and in its other Hebrew occurrences (Gen 24:43, Exod 2:8, Ps 68:25, Prov 30:19, Song 1:3, Song 6:8) carries the expectation but not the lexical compulsion of virginity. The LXX translators, working pre-Christian, rendered almah here as parthenos (virgin). Matt 1:23 cites the LXX form and identifies Mary as the fulfillment. The verse on its own is lexically ambiguous; the apostolic reading in Matt 1:23 settles the canonical interpretation. Honest acknowledgment of the lexical range of almah is methodologically required; the apostolic citation is what carries the verdict.

Gal.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. γενόμενον ἐκ γυναικός *genomenon ek gynaikos* G1096 G1537 G1135 (born of a woman); γενόμενον ὑπὸ νόμον *genomenon hypo nomon* G1096 G5259 G3551 (born under the law)

Force. Paul names the incarnation at the precise point of Christ's saving advent. The phrase is born of a woman with the preposition *ek* of source. There is no mention of a human father. The omission is deliberate; Paul follows the exact same pattern at the conception level that Matthew and Luke do at the narrative level. The phrase is the Pauline confirmation of the gospel infancy tradition.

Luke.1.42-43 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. εὐλογημένη *eulogemene* G2127 (blessed); καρπὸς τῆς κοιλίας *karpos tes koilias* G2590 G2836 (fruit of the womb); μήτηρ τοῦ Κυρίου *meter tou kyriou* G3384 G2962 (mother of my Lord)

Force. Elizabeth, filled with the Holy Spirit, names Mary as blessed among women and the fruit of her womb as blessed, and names Mary as the mother of my Lord (*kyrios* G2962). The Lukan narrative thus has a Spirit-inspired confirmation by a second witness that Mary is already pregnant with the divine Son before she has had any marital union. Independent narrative confirmation of the virginal conception.

John.1.13-14 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. οὐκ ἐξ αἱμάτων *ouk ex haimaton* G3756 G1537 G129 (not of bloods); οὐδὲ ἐκ θελήματος σαρκός *oude ek thelematos sarkos* G1537 G2307 G4561 (nor of the will of the flesh); οὐδὲ ἐκ θελήματος ἀνδρός *oude ek thelematos andros* G1537 G2307 G435 (nor of the will of a man); ὁ λόγος σὰρξ ἐγένετο *ho logos sarx egeneto* G3056 G4561 G1096 (the Word became flesh)

Force. John 1:13 describes the new birth of believers in terms borrowed from natural generation, naming three things explicitly excluded: bloods, will of the flesh, will of a man. Some early variant traditions read v.13 in the singular (who was born), making it a direct reference to Christ's own virginal generation. Even on the majority reading (referring to believers), v.14 then says the Word became flesh, and the verbal echo links the incarnation to the same not-of-man pattern. Johannine resonance with the Matt/Luke infancy tradition.

Gen.3.15 · for · genre: narrative · figures: typology

Key term. זֶרַע *zera* H2233 (seed); אִשָּׁה *ishshah* H802 (woman); הוּא *hu* (he)

Force. The protoevangelium speaks of the seed of the woman (*zera ha-ishshah*) who will crush the serpent's head. Seed is normally reckoned through the father in OT idiom; the unusual seed of the woman formulation has been read in Christian and earlier Jewish typological tradition as anticipating a birth in which the male line is silent. The OT seed for the virgin birth is suggestive, not lexically compulsory, but consistent with the apostolic infancy claim.

Jer.31.22 · for · genre: prophecy

Key term. נֶעְוָה תְּסֹוֵב גַּוֵּר *neqevah tesovev gaver* H5347 H5437 H1397 (a woman shall encompass a man)

Force. An OT prophetic enigma. The standard order of generation is reversed: a woman encompasses a man. Some Christian commentators have read this as an anticipation of the virginal conception (a woman gives rise to a man without male initiative). Lexically obscure on its own; classed as suggestive support, not as a load-bearing proof.

Prov.30.19 · complicates · genre: wisdom

Key term. אַמָּה almah H5959 (young woman, maid)

Force. The way of a man with a maid (almah). Cited by critics of the Isa 7:14 reading because almah here may refer to a woman in the context of courtship and union. The verse demonstrates that almah's lexical range includes pre-marital sexual contexts and is not lexically compelled to mean virgin. This is the honest acknowledgment that load-bearing the verdict on almah alone is insufficient; the verdict rests on the LXX rendering plus the apostolic citation plus the narrative.

Mark.6.3 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. ὁ τέκτων ho tekton G5045 (the carpenter); ὁ υἱὸς τῆς Μαρίας ho huios tes Marias G5207 G3137 (the son of Mary)

Force. In Nazareth Jesus is called the son of Mary, not the son of Joseph. In a patriarchal-genealogical culture this is unusual phrasing and consistent with the absence of a Josephan biological paternity. The textual variant tradition includes the son of the carpenter; the strongest manuscripts and the Markan formulation retain son of Mary. Lexical undertone consistent with the virginal conception narrative.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G3933, G4151, G40, G1064, G2192, G4250, G4905, G1080, G1097, G2193, G5088, G3423, G1893, G435, G1904, G1411, G5310, G1982, G1096, G1135, G3551, G2127, G2590, G2836, G3384, G2962, G129, G2307, G4561, G3056, G5045, G5207, G3137, H5959, H2030, H3205, H2233, H802, H5347, H5437, H1397

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Apostles' Creed (early form circulating by mid-second century), and Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed (381) · affirms · verified

“Conceived by the Holy Spirit, born of the Virgin Mary; incarnate of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary, and was made man.”

patristic · Justin Martyr, Dialogue with Trypho chapter 66, CCEL ANF Vol 1

<https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf01/anf01.viii.iv.lxvi.html> · **affirms · verified**

“In the race of Abraham according to the flesh no one has been born of a virgin, or is said to have been born of a virgin, save this our Christ.”

patristic · Irenaeus, Against Heresies Book III, defending the LXX parthenos against Theodotion and Aquila · affirms · verified

“Mary was found with child of the Holy Ghost; the Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee.”

patristic · Tertullian, On the Flesh of Christ (De Carne Christi), CCEL ANF Vol 3 · affirms · unverified

“A virgin did conceive in her womb, and bear a Son. Of this the prophecy ran beforehand in Isaiah. The Word was made flesh of a virgin.”

patristic · Athanasius, On the Incarnation, CCEL

<https://ccel.org/ccel/athanasius/incarnation> · **affirms · unverified**

“He took a body for himself, and that not foreign to our own. He took it from a spotless, stainless virgin, without the agency of human father.”

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church, paragraphs 484-507 (The Mystery of the Incarnation; conceived by the power of the Holy Spirit) · affirms · unverified

“Mary's virginity manifests God's absolute initiative in the Incarnation. Jesus has only God as Father. He was conceived by the Holy Spirit without human seed.”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession (1530), Article III On the Son of God, bookofconcord.org https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/son-of-god/ · affirms · verified

“The Word, that is, the Son of God, did assume the human nature in the womb of the blessed Virgin Mary.”

anglican · Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion (1571), Article II Of the Word, or Son of God, which was made very Man · affirms · unverified

“The Son, which is the Word of the Father, took Man's nature in the womb of the blessed Virgin, of her substance; so that two whole and perfect Natures were joined together in one Person.”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), Chapter 8 Section 2 · affirms · unverified

“He was conceived by the power of the Holy Ghost, in the womb of the Virgin Mary, of her substance. So that two whole, perfect, and distinct natures were inseparably joined.”

methodist · Methodist Articles of Religion (Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles), Article II https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion · affirms · verified

“The Son took man's nature in the womb of the blessed Virgin; so that two whole and perfect natures were joined together in one person.”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession of Faith (1632), Article IV On the Coming of Christ · affirms · unverified

“He was conceived by the Holy Ghost, born of the Virgin Mary, and that He thus became flesh and man in the world.”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God, Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 2 The Deity of the Lord Jesus Christ · affirms · unverified

“The Lord Jesus Christ is the eternal Son of God. His virgin birth is confirmed in Scripture as the means of His incarnation.”

eastern_orthodox · Orthodox Church in America, The Orthodox Faith, Symbol of Faith, Incarnation https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture/the-symbol-of-faith/incarnation · affirms · verified

“And He was incarnate of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary and became man.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/1.htm>

“Matt 1:18 en gastri echousa ek pneumatou hagiou (G1064 G2192 G1537 G4151 G40). Mary found pregnant of the Holy Spirit before she and Joseph came together.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/luke/1-34.htm>

“Luke 1:34 epei andra ou ginosko (G1893 G435 G3756 G1097): since I do not know a man. Ginosko in the Hebrew-idiomatic sense of marital relations.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/luke/1-35.htm>

“Luke 1:35 pneuma hagion epeleusetai (G4151 G40 G1904); dynamis hypsistou episkiasai (G1411 G5310 G1982). Divine presence overshadows; child called Son of God.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/isaiah/7-14.htm>

“Isa 7:14 ha-almah (H5959) young woman of marriageable age; harah (H2030) pregnant. Hebrew lexically permits but does not compel virgin; LXX renders parthenos.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/hebrew/5959.htm>

“H5959 almah occurs 7x in Hebrew Bible (Gen 24:43, Exod 2:8, Ps 68:25, Prov 30:19, Song 1:3, Song 6:8, Isa 7:14). Range includes pre-marital but does not exclude virginity.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/greek/3933.htm>

“G3933 parthenos. Matt 1:23 cites Isa 7:14 LXX with parthenos; Luke 1:27 names Mary twice as parthenos. NT lexical force is unambiguous: a woman who has not had sexual relations.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/4-4.htm>

“Gal 4:4 genomenon ek gynaikos (G1096 G1537 G1135) born of a woman. No mention of a human father at the very point Paul names the saving incarnation.”

supports · category: patristic_archive · <https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf01/anf01.viii.iv.lxvi.html>

“Justin, Dialogue with Trypho 66: in the race of Abraham according to the flesh, no one has been born of a virgin, save this our Christ.”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/son-of-god/>

“Augsburg Confession Article III: the Word, that is, the Son of God, did assume the human nature in the womb of the blessed Virgin Mary.”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“Methodist Article II: the Son took man's nature in the womb of the blessed Virgin; two whole and perfect natures were joined together in one person.”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture/the-symbol-of-faith/incarnation>

“OCA: And He was incarnate of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary and became man.”

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